

do. Your style has to change. As a start-up entrepreneur you have to be aware of all the elements and perhaps the partners who are helping you in that process—whether finance, technical or sales. As the company grows, you have to start delegating. For every challenge, my style has been to figure out one of the officers from the company and then delegate the role. I started with the simplest things to delegate and gradually delegated the more complex roles. The hardest of all, to delegate, is the core strategy and vision.

A basic thumb-rule could be that when you get about 70 people, you have to start working on delegation. When you get to 300 you have to have more formal structure in place, and when you get to 1000 you really have to have a very well formed management structure for each of the functions in place.

I, for one, delegated things after having figured out how to get things done in those departments or functions. So some of the things I delegated quickly included manufacturing, accounts, and sales and marketing.

I still, from time-to-time, look at the specific elements of products but, more and more, I am now building a team that really understands the vision and key architectures at the top. We actually have a routine meeting of the architects and the visionaries of the company to see whether we are building the products in keeping with the vision that we have.

How do you define your current role now? What are the things you focus on and which aspects have you delegated?

Internally, I work on driving the vision. Plus, I regularly meet my key executives to look at the product strategy, specific products and how things are shaping up with respect to our vision. So, I am still very hands-on in that process.

I believe the success of a company depends on the leadership driving the vision. For example, we recently introduced our vector signal transceiver, and I spent a great deal of time in the process of getting it to align with our vision of what we are trying to do with FPGAs, multi-core and ensure that we deliver a truly visionary product in the marketplace.

How do you manage the HR side of business?

I do spend quite a bit of time recruiting, all the way to giving the vision presentation to young graduates.

When it comes to recruits, there are two popular techniques: the stone wall and the brick wall. In the stone wall technique, you try to match the skill and talents with the job of the person. So when you put together stones of different sizes and different shapes and they fit, you get this brilliant wall. The other one is where you try to find people who can match the requirements of a position.

I prefer the stone wall technique—when I look at some-

We should always look at the long term when we make decisions, and also at the timeline to know when these decisions need to be made and executed

one, I look at his strengths and talents and then I complement them over time.

How do you complement people over time w.r.t. their talents?

Well, I can list some very brilliant people who have communication issues. They may say something in a manner that might confuse their subordinates. So you have to complement them with people who can communicate well. Similarly, you find folks that are really good at implementation but don't want to work on the big picture view, so you need to find somebody who matches that profile. Overall, you have to keep looking for the right pieces to fit in the puzzle.

Right now, a lot of people pit discipline vs creativity. What is more important to you, as an entrepreneur?

We aim to reach a balance between the two—a sort of harmonious relationship between the two attributes. We hire based on both of them. Obviously, there has to be creativity to define a unique opportunity but without discipline it is of no use.

What is the secret behind maintaining a continued growth over the years?

NI has a strong track record of sustainable growth and profitability because we are managed for the long term. We believe the fundamental drivers of our long-term sustained growth have been new product R&D and a strong sales force. Over the last few years, we invested aggressively in innovation through research and development, with the output being new products that build on our highly differentiated platform. Similarly, with our strategic investments in developing a strong sales force, we are positioned to help our customers find ways to lower their costs, improve their productivity and help them bring their own innovative products to the market quickly.

How important is India for you, as a market?

NI IndRA (India, Russia and Arabia) represents one of the company's fastest growing regions, and we are excited about the significant outcome of NI's strategic and long-term R&D investment in India. As India's influence on the global marketplace grows, the NI India team collaborates with hundreds of customers in universities, SMEs and multinational corporations to nurture local innovation and accelerate productivity. ●

(The complete interview can be viewed at electronicsforu.com)